

Cholent

Itsi Weinstock - adapted from Forverts

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Preparation 1

1. Chop 2 **onions**.

Cooking 1

1. Cook **onions** in 2 tbsp oil in a pot on medium until translucent.

Preparation 2

2. *Spices group:*
 - 1 tbsp **sweet paprika**
 - 1 tbsp **smoked paprika**
 - 1 tsp **cumin seeds**
 - 1 tsp **caraway seeds**
 - 2 **bay leaves**
 - 5 cloves of **garlic**, minced
3. *Sofrito group:*
 - 1 **carrot** grated
 - 1 **capsicum** diced

Cooking 2

2. Add the **spices** and cook for 1 minute.
3. Add the **sofrito**, and 1 tsp of salt, and cook until extremely soft (up to 15 minutes).

Preparation 3

4. *Beans group:*
 - 1/2 cup of **dried pinto beans**
 - 1/4 cup of **dried red kidney beans**
 - 1/4 cup of **dried lima beans**
 - 1/4 cup of **pearl barley**
5. Rinse the beans.
6. Cut the potatoes into big chunks.

Cooking 3

4. Add the **beans** and potatoes, cover with an inch of water, and cook it to death. Either in a dutch oven in the oven on a gentle simmer for 18 hours, a slow cooker on low for 12-18 hours, or a pressure cooker on high for 2 hours.
5. Add 1/4 tsp **msg**, a ton of pepper, the juice of half a **lemon**, and salt to taste.

Servings: 3

Ingredients:

2	onions
1	carrot
1	capsicum
3 medium	potatoes (stewing variety)
5 cloves	garlic
1/2	lemon
1/2 cup	dried pinto beans
1/4 cup	dried kidney beans
1/4 cup	dried lima beans
1/4 cup	pearl barley
2	bay leaves
1 tbsp	sweet paprika
1 tbsp	smoked paprika
1 tsp	cumin seeds
1 tsp	caraway seeds
1/4 tsp	msg

Discussion

This recipe is very much a work in progress. The goal of this dish is to get a really “cholent”, flavour. Tasting a real cholent, there’s something great that comes out of the beans when cooked the right way, and it’s hard to achieve. Small changes to cooking method have enormous impact on the flavour.

Acidity

An in depth dive into Chana Masala (chickpea curry) will tell you that chickpeas cannot be cooked in acidic environments (such as a curry base), so they have to be cooked first. A basic environment can speed up the cook time by 75% (see baking soda + tea bag experiment [youtube.com/watch?v=IGtGx2fWz4Y](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IGtGx2fWz4Y)). With all bean dishes: acidity must be added at the end of cooking. No deglazing with wine or any of that jazz. The baking soda/tea bag method may be useful here too.

Glutimates

The traditional Ashkenazi method employs marrow bones that really add something when cooked to death. There’s no amazing vegan substitute here, because restricting acidity means no wine or tomato paste. An argument may be made for miso as a bean derivative, but it feels wrong and also introduces acidity and a strong flavour. I think the way to go here is straight MSG.

Beans

There are so many beans. Pinto beans have a really great flavour. Kidney beans have a great colour and release a really sticky liquid that adds to the texture. Lima beans add body and variety, but are fairly flavourless so could be replaced. There’s a whole world out there to explore. I suggest consulting with grandmothers on this topic. Also to be considered is the ratio of barley to beans.

Sofrito

Traditional Yiddish recipes call for celeriac in the sofrito. I subscribe to Itsi’s allium rule on this one: Different cuisines pick their alliums/sofritos based on what is cheap where their culture exists (Indian food **always** uses red onions). Use whatever’s cheap from the sofrito category of veg: things that’ll dissolve after a lot of cooking.

Root veg

Sweet potato and other root veg are sometimes used.

Story

As far as I’ve been able to research, there are only 3 Jewish foods - in that they are eaten across all diasporas/ethnic groups. **Matzah**, a flavourless ceremonial cracker eaten as the staple food during Pesach; **Charoset**, another ceremonial Pesach food meant to resemble mortar and made of fruits and spices and often nuts and wine. The last is **Cholent** and its regional counterparts.

A Jewish law forbids cooking on the Sabbath. The crafty Jews found a loophole. As long as they personally weren’t actively cooking, they could get away with food being made. The idea was to start cooking before Friday evening (a few hours earlier to be safe), and then leave whatever they made in a hot place (a conveniently premade fire or the baker’s oven as it turned off). Then all they had to do was run into it for lunch the next day. This process required food to be cooked for over 18 hours. Hence only slow cookable things are put in, like beans and grains and, later, meat. A similar dish pops up in all diasporas. Sephardi Chamim, Iraqi Tbeet, Moroccan Skhina, Maghreb Adafina, Uzbek Oshi Sabo. The Ashkenazi version is Cholent. It uses the ingredients common in eastern Europe: beans, barley, root vegetables, paprika.

The slow cooker was invented to cook cholent.